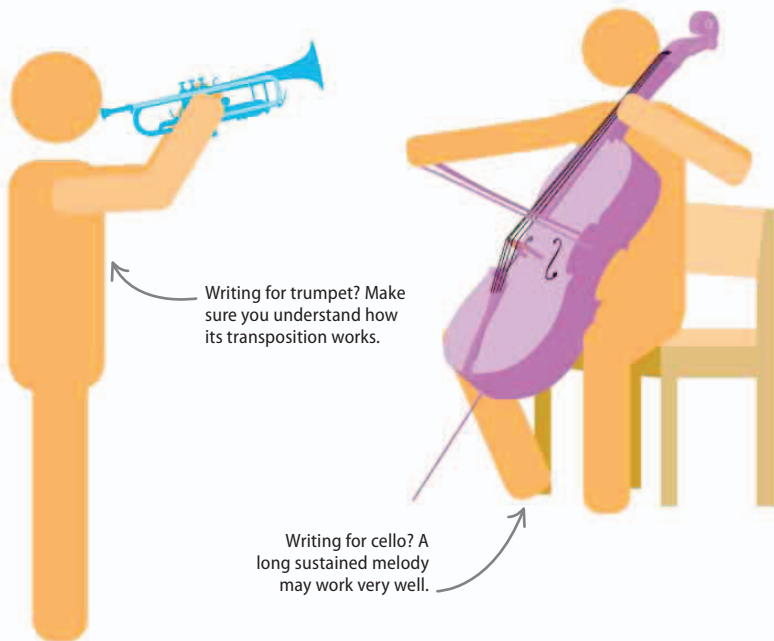


What voice or instrument is it for?

What you write must be playable on the instrument for which you are writing. Make sure that the range is right, and try not to create difficulties—consult a player if possible. It helps if you are writing for your own instrument! For voices or wind instruments, allow space to breathe.



△ The right instrument for the music

Writing for instruments requires an appreciation of their character—what they do well and what is best avoided. It is always helpful to talk to players and pick up hints as to what works best.

REAL WORLD

A quiet place

To write a good original melody you need peace and quiet, so you can hear it in your head and then work out how to write it down. Gustav Mahler, Edvard Grieg, and Jean Sibelius are examples of composers who had a favored place to which they could retreat when composing. This picture shows Mahler's cabin on the lakeside at Steinbach, Austria, where he wrote his Second Symphony.



Melody-writing in exam conditions

If you are sitting an exam and the question gives you an opening, first look at the meter (the time signature) and then the tempo, and work out how the rhythm goes. Then look at the key signature, and from the opening notes work out what key it is in, and if it is major or minor. Silently sing the given opening to yourself in your head; then you can imagine how it might continue.



◁ On the line, or in the space?

When handwriting your music, be as clear as possible. Never write a note like this. Is it on the line or in the space? Always be 100 percent clear which pitch you want.



◁ Be clear, be detailed

Write your music in a clear, well-spaced, accurate way. Add plenty of detail: articulations, dynamics, expression marks, a tempo indication, slurs, or phrase marks.